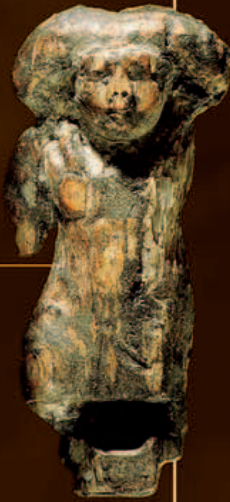


Measured against the estimated 4.5-billion-year age of Earth itself, humans—anatomically modern humans in particular—evolved remarkably recently. Modern man—*Homo sapiens*—appeared only about 150,000 years ago, rapidly migrating from African homelands to join other human species—*Homo erectus* in Asia and, across Europe and the Middle East,

the Neanderthals. By about 24,000 years ago, *Homo sapiens*, socially more sophisticated, had become the sole human species. Then, in the Middle East, about 6,000 years ago, settled and increasingly complex societies emerged. With them came the first cities and the first states. It was the birth of civilization as we know it today.

8000 BCE		6000 BCE		5000 BCE		4000 BCE		»	
									
◀ Obsidian c. 7000 BCE First Chinese agricultural communities, Yangzi Valley. Agriculture spreads to southeast Europe from modern Turkey.		c. 6000 BCE Early town cultures, such as the Halafian in southwest Asia, flourish. Linearbandkeramik pot ▼		▲ Corn c. 5000 BCE Corn cultivated in Ecuador and parts of North America. Cultivation of corn begins in Tehuacán valley, Central America.		c. 4000 BCE First use of plow in Mesopotamia.		c. 3100 BCE King Narmer completes unification of Upper and Lower Egypt and becomes first pharaoh. Nekhen, Egypt, an important trading town. ◀ Warka vase, Uruk	
									
▲ Çatalhöyük figurine c. 6500 BCE Copper smelting and trade in obsidian at Catalhöyük, modern Turkey.		c. 5500 BCE World's earliest irrigation system, Mesopotamia.		c. 5000 BCE Copper first used in Mesopotamia; gold and copper artifacts produced in southeast Europe.		c. 3500 BCE Emergence of world's first city-states in Mesopotamia; Uruk possibly the world's first city. c. 3350 BCE "Ötzi the ice man" dies in the Alps. Nekhen ivory ▶		c. 8000 BCE Foundation of Jericho, Palestine, the world's oldest continuously inhabited town. ▼ Domesticated cattle	
c. 6500 BCE Cattle successfully domesticated in North Africa, the Indus Valley, and Asia.		c. 5500–4500 BCE Linearbandkeramik farming culture flourishes, Central Europe. Halaf figurine ▶		c. 4500 BCE Introduction of irrigation techniques in Indus valley. Horse domesticated in Central Asia.		c. 3200 BCE First hieroglyphic script in Egypt. Evidence of use of wheeled transport in Sumer. Stone circles and rows of standing stones built in north and west Europe.			